

Sabalenka opens China Open with victory and discusses self-pressure

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Aryna Sabalenka began her China Open **campaign** by beating Mexico's Renata Zarazua. After the match, she discussed her efforts to be easier on herself while dealing with high **expectations**.

The world number two won 6-1, 6-3 in 63 minutes. She hit 11 **aces** and did not face a break point. An ace is a legal serve that the **receiver** does not touch. A break point gives the **receiver** a chance to win a game on the opponent's serve.

This was Sabalenka's first match since losing her world number one ranking and her US Open crown to Elena Rybakina in September. She was seeking her first title since March, when she won Indian Wells and the Miami Open **back-to-back**. That pair of victories is known as the Sunshine Double.

Sabalenka explained that demanding more from herself has both helpful and difficult effects. Sometimes those **expectations** push her forward, she said, but sometimes they drain her energy.

She said: "I'm really trying so hard sometimes to be easier on myself."

Her comments describe how she experiences pressure in her own tennis career. She said learning to be less **self-critical** was something she still needed to work on.

Sabalenka was set to face Czech player Nikola Bartunkova in the third round. Bartunkova had come close to beating her at the Berlin Open in June. The China Open victory gave Sabalenka a winning start as she continued her search for another tournament title.

Word Treasure

campaign -- A player's effort to progress through a tournament.

aces -- Legal serves that the receiver does not touch.

receiver -- The player who tries to return a serve.

expectations -- Beliefs or hopes about how well someone should do.

self-critical -- Quick to judge your own actions or results harshly.

back-to-back -- One after the other.

Background you need

An ace is a legal serve that the receiver does not touch.

A break point is an opportunity for the receiver to win a game on the opponent's serve.

Break it down

Opens with Sabalenka's victory and her discussion of expectations.

Reports match statistics and explains two tennis terms.

Adds context about September and her March titles.

Presents Sabalenka's explanation of self-pressure and a direct quote.

Closes with her scheduled third-round opponent and title search.

Why it matters

Sabalenka's account explains how high expectations can both motivate an athlete and take energy, alongside a concrete tournament result.

Test what you remember

1. What was the score of Sabalenka's win over Zarazua?
 - (A) 6-2, 6-4
 - (B) 6-1, 6-3
 - (C) 6-4, 6-2
 - (D) 6-3, 6-1
2. What chance does a break point give the receiver?
 - (A) To win a game on the opponent's serve
 - (B) To change the score of the previous game
 - (C) To choose a different opponent that day
 - (D) To take a pause before the next set
3. Who took Sabalenka's number one ranking and US Open crown in September?
 - (A) Nikola Bartunkova
 - (B) Elena Rybakina
 - (C) Aryna Sabalenka
 - (D) Renata Zarazua
4. What does the Sunshine Double refer to in the article?
 - (A) Winning Indian Wells and the Miami Open
 - (B) Winning the Berlin Open and the China Open
 - (C) Winning Indian Wells and the China Open
 - (D) Winning the Berlin Open and the Miami Open
5. How did Sabalenka describe demanding more from herself?
 - (A) It can guarantee titles or prevent defeats
 - (B) It can change her opponent or match score
 - (C) It can motivate her or drain her energy
 - (D) It can shorten matches or remove all pressure
6. Where had Bartunkova come close to beating Sabalenka in June?
 - (A) At the China Open
 - (B) At the US Open
 - (C) At the Berlin Open
 - (D) At the Miami Open

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: A 3: B 4: A 5: C 6: C

Questions to think about

1. Aryna Sabalenka: She described her high expectations as sometimes helpful and sometimes draining, and said she was trying to be easier on herself.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):